



Mostly cloudy 58/56 • Tomorrow: Rain, t-storm 62/33 B6

Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, DECEMBER 10, 2024 • \$3

Suspect in shooting of CEO arrested

26-year-old faces gun and first-degree murder charges in New York

BY MARK BERMAN AND SHAYNA JACOBS

Authorities said Monday that they had taken a 26-year-old man into custody in connection with the killing of Brian Thompson, a health insurance executive who was gunned down last week on a Manhattan sidewalk.

The shooting sparked a sprawling five-day manhunt that ended in Altoona, Pennsylvania, where police said Luigi Mangione, a Maryland native, was spotted eating at a local McDonald's. He was arrested and charged with five counts, including possessing an instrument of a crime, providing false identification to law enforcement and carrying a firearm without a license.



Mangione Police said Mangione had a ghost gun, along with a lengthy handwritten document indicating anger toward "corporate America."

"He is believed to be our person of interest in the brazen, targeted murder of Brian Thompson," Jessica Tisch, the New York City police commissioner, said at a news briefing.

Late Monday on the New York state court's website, charges were listed under Mangione's name including first-degree murder, illegal gun possession and possessing a forged instrument. No additional

SEE ARREST ON A16

'Deny, Defend, Depose': Amazon bans shooting-themed merch. **A16**



LORENZO TUGNOLI FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Civilians in Damascus, Syria, gather at one of Bashar al-Assad's palaces on Monday after it was looted. Assad's sudden fall Sunday has left residents in a state of stunned disbelief. Some spent Monday picking through the homes and palaces of the ousted leader and his family.

U.S. scrambles to respond to unexpected collapse

BY KAREN DEYOUNG, MICHAEL BIRNBAUM AND MISSY RYAN

Of all the foreign upheavals that the Biden administration has had to confront and manage in recent years, Syria was not on anyone's list of likely crises.

A U.S.-backed Syrian peace process, begun after civil war broke out in 2011, was moribund. Lines dividing the country into spheres of influence among world and regional powers hadn't changed significantly for years. Arab governments that once worked to dislodge Iranian-

Diplomats rush to region to help foster Syria's transition, stability

backed President Bashar al-Assad had started to enfold him in their embrace.

The sudden offensive launched by the Islamist Hayat Tahrir al-Sham (HTS) rebel group, leading to the collapse of Assad's government and military forces in less than two weeks, has left governments around the world scrambling

to figure out what to do about it, none more so than the Biden administration.

Senior U.S. diplomats have rushed to the region, fanning out for discussions in Turkey, Jordan, Lebanon, Iraq and Israel. Egypt and Saudi Arabia are also involved in talks about an effort to maintain stability in Syria and attempt to foster some sort of political transition.

The United Nations Security Council, whose rotating presidency is currently held by the United States, held a closed-door meeting Monday afternoon with the U.N. special envoy for Syria and the

head of U.N. peacekeeping forces in charge of monitoring a ceasefire between Israel and Syria since the 1973 Yom Kippur War.

Since Assad's fall, Israeli forces have made limited incursions into the U.N.-monitored buffer zone from the Golan Heights — Syrian territory it occupied during the war and later annexed — and have carried out airstrikes targeting what Israel says are suspected chemical weapons and missile sites in Syria to prevent them from "falling into the wrong hands," according to Israeli Foreign Minister Gideon Saar.

SEE DIPLOMACY ON A12

Joy and unease blanket Syrians

RESIDENTS TAKE IN A CHANGED DAMASCUS

Rebels try to reassure public they'll bring order

BY LOVEDAY MORRIS AND SUZAN HAIDAMOUS

DAMASCUS, SYRIA — The three-starred revolutionary flags hoisted over the central squares of Damascus hold the promise of a free Syria.

But the rapturous celebrations in the streets Monday were tempered by trepidation over whether the country's new caretakers could deliver on that dream.

The sudden fall of Bashar al-Assad in the early hours of Sunday morning has left the Syrian capital in a state of stunned disbelief. A day later, some residents were emerging for the first time to take in the changed face of the city.

They picked through the homes and palaces of the ousted president and his family, marveling at the wealth they had accumulated over more than half a century of dynastic rule, as Syrians sank ever deeper into poverty.

"We just want to feel the moment," said Siham Bader, 55, dressed in a baby-blue coat, as she joined the crowds wandering

SEE SYRIA ON A11

Refugees: Some in Europe say it is time for Syrians to return home. **A10**

Israel reacts: Troops in the Golan Heights enter southern Syria. **A11**

Austin Tice: U.S. special envoy is aiding efforts to find journalist. **A12**

EPA bans two common but harmful chemicals

Known carcinogens TCE and perc pose threats to humans, environment

BY AMUDALAT AJASA

The Environmental Protection Agency on Monday banned two known carcinogens used in a variety of consumer products and industrial settings that can seep into the environment through the soil and waterways.

The new rules, which underscore President Joe Biden's efforts to enact key protections against harmful chemicals before leaving office, include the complete ban of trichloroethylene — also known as TCE — a substance found in degreasing agents, furniture care and auto repair products. The agency also banned all consumer uses and many commercial uses of perc — also known as perchloroethylene and PCE — an industrial solvent long used in applications such as dry cleaning and auto repair.

"Both of these chemicals have caused too much harm for too long, despite the existence of

SEE EPA ON A7

Environmental programs: Trump may cut Biden's initiatives. **A4**



ANNABEL CLARK FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

LGBTQ+ people fear a rollback of their rights in another Trump term

BY MAHAM JAVAID AND CASEY PARKS

Zoi Montgomery is so nervous about Donald Trump's second presidency that she is making plans to escape to Canada if life in the United States becomes intolerable for her as a transgender woman.

The middle-school custodian fears that the incoming president will follow the lead of Republican governors who have restricted access to gender-affirming care and made it illegal for people to change their gender markers on official documents.

Zoi Montgomery said that if her access to gender transition care becomes limited, she's prepared to escape to Canada.

Another fight: Va. library faces a new challenge. **B1**

"I would hate to leave home," said Montgomery, 25, who lives in Washington state. "But it makes me less anxious to have an exit plan in place."

As Trump's inauguration nears, some LGBTQ+ people are anxiously preparing for what they fear will be a rollback of their rights. Some in same-sex relationships are making plans to marry or to adopt children. Others are moving to states that they believe will offer them more protection. Transgender people are

SEE LGBTQ+ ON A8

Gold bar scams hit \$6M, Montgomery police say

Suspect denied bond in latest elaborate scheme targeting older residents

BY DAN MORSE

The couple faced an urgent choice: Either pull \$263,000 from their bank account, convert it to gold bars and hand the bars over for safekeeping, or the funds would go to hackers supplying missiles to Russia.

Over several weeks, since getting a call to their home in Bethesda, Maryland, the married couple spoke with purported professionals from Apple, Charles Schwab and the Federal Trade Commission. The men persuaded the couple, who are both 75, that \$41,500 from their account had already been spent on child pornography. With the Russian missile suppliers closing in, they were assured, a safe haven was being offered.

It was all, Montgomery County Police say, one big con — the latest elaborate scam in which county residents, some as old as 94, have given more than \$6.6 million worth of gold bars in furtive exchanges, never to see those bars again.

Charged in the most recent case is Yongxian Huang, a 23-year-old from New York, who made his first appearance in Montgomery District Court on Monday and was

ordered to stay in jail without bond. "He's a danger to the vulnerable public," Judge Holly Reed said from the bench.

Montgomery police say he tried at least once to pick up gold bars from the Bethesda couple and conspired with others to take more. Investigators closed in on Huang last month after running a scheme themselves in which a female detective — posing as the woman — handed over a box of fake gold bars.

Huang's case is surfacing while another New York man, Yash Shah, 26, was charged recently by Montgomery authorities who say he worked with others last year to steal \$2.3 million in gold bars from an 88-year-old Bethesda woman and her daughter. The pair had been convinced that handing over the bars would help the Justice Department catch criminals siphoning their money to fund child pornography, human trafficking and illegal Chinese gambling games, according to court records. The subsequent gold bar exchanges, the records state, went down in parking lots outside an Old Navy store, a DSW Designer Shoe Warehouse and Westfield Montgomery Mall, according to court files.

"They create a sense of urgency. You want to get this cleared up right away," said FBI Supervisory Special Agent Keith Custer, who has investigated gold bar scams from the bureau's Baltimore field

SEE SCAM ON A20

IN THE NEWS

Slow and steady A key goal in operating Perseverance is making sure the Mars rover always lives to drive another day. **A20**

Mother charged with murder A behavioral health specialist in Chevy Chase, Maryland, confessed to drowning her 3-month-old daughter, according to court records. **B1**

THE NATION Sen. Joni Ernst (R) said a meeting with Pete Hegseth included "really good discussions." **A2** Daniel Penny was acquitted of criminally negligent homicide in Jordan Neely's death. **A3**

THE WORLD A Haitian gang allegedly massacred scores of older people over a claim of witchcraft. **A13** South Korea's embattled president, Yoon Suk Yeol, was barred from leaving his country. **A14**

THE ECONOMY The number of parents citing child-care-related work disruptions is higher than at the peak of the coronavirus crisis, new research finds. **A15** TikTok asked a federal appeals court to pause a law that could shut down the app in the United States next month. **A15**

THE REGION The District's mayor credited a more aggressive approach to fighting crime with helping to drive down violence. **B1** A Maryland principal has been put on leave as officials investigate the recent discovery of a racial slur written on a Black student's desk. **B1**

STYLE Could weight-loss medications help treat addiction? Studies are promising, but it may be too soon to be sure. **C1**

HEALTH & SCIENCE At 102, a Manhattan woman is an extraordinary example of an older adult living by herself and thriving. **E1**

BUSINESS NEWS.....A15
COMICS.....C5
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A17
TELEVISION.....C4
WORLD NEWS.....A10

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The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54061

